philosophy was, from the beginning, fundamentally anti-bastard, and, coarse as that seems, it's also got a certain honesty.

Before the launch, the finance for registering domain names and so on came from me. Everybody else contributed their time for free. From the start, we knew we would face legal challenges and I was keen to register as much as possible in San Francisco, knowing that the civil liberties movement there would prove to be significant fire-power on our behalf once we got into trouble. After that, it was just a case of emailing everybody we could think of and waiting for the responses.

Our first leaked document, which we published on 28 December 2006, seemed to come from the Union of Islamic Courts in Somalia, though, as we explained at the time, it was of mysterious provenance, coming to us via a Chinese source, and we couldn't be sure that it was genuine. Following years of violence in Somalia, which had already seen the secession of around two-thirds of the country, the Union had begun to establish some kind of order out of the chaos. People began to feel safer in Mogadishu and ordinary citizens became more confident that they would be protected from everyday violence and the frequent systematic looting by warlords. Our leaked document purported to be a letter from a military commander, an inflammatory instruction in which he referred to the 'Islamic Republic of Somalia', a form of words rarely used by the Union. 'As you are all aware,' the commander wrote, 'the so-called Transitional Government formed for Somalia is hunting the Somali religious leaders and the Muslims in general. They have influenced the International Community to believe that the Somali religious leaders are Al-Qaeda.' Intercepted email traffic that was passed to us along with this document seemed to imply that Somali ministers, including the minister for petroleum, were preparing to meet with Chinese officials. It appeared to reveal something that people should have known about the Somali attitude to China and the Chinese attitude to Africa.

This situation in Somalia was getting no real attention in the West at the time, and here, in two small documents, one could begin to see how complex the situation was. The Union really was trying to make a difference: under them, the garbage was collected in Mogadishu for the first time in eleven years. But, whatever they did, the US were unthinkingly opposed to them through their strongest regional ally Ethiopia, seeing any kind of politicisation of Islam in East Africa as somehow linked to the 1998